

To Know

“Somewhere in the world there’s a bottomless well of soup. Old hand-crank bucket and string type thing. And any kinda soup you want too, really, yeah, for real. Nope, I don’t got a clue where it could be—don’t think anybody’s found it to be honest. But like, you know. If I, well, you know. S’no fountain of youth, but I wouldn’t be out tellin’ people either.”

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A hypothetical: over the next couple years you might lose your keys, might misplace them. Keys to your house, your car—they’ll probably show up soon, you’ll think—your desk, your safe—they’d *better* show up soon—success, a happier life, etc. etc. You’ll look for them once you notice of course, that’s what one does, of course. Remember to always “reclaim what’s yours,” to always shake your fist.⁵ Access, among other things, is a privilege: if you don’t have, you cannot have.

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I found myself on a walk the other day. Late in the evening, after dinner. It was dark and a bit chilly. It’s nearing the solstice, so. I’d wanted some fresh air, but fog set in as I set out. So be it. I wasn’t wholly sure of where I wanted to go, but that was fine. I had nowhere to be, after all. I wished I hadn’t left my coat though, the wind was picking up. But I couldn’t yet see my breath (it was dark, there was fog), and wouldn’t be out for long. The fog remained unperturbed.

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“Yeah, sure, I’ve absolutely looked for it, I mean what’d you expect, right? Don’t got the means to go *that* far though, so, no luck, obviously. Can’t just be in my backyard, right? Mm, yeah. It’s the type’a thing you’d think’d be deep in some jungle, like lost ruins or something, but I sure ain’t gonna trek through the Amazon by myself. And hey, we don’t know where it is, so, could be smack-dab in the middle of some city, could be in the Colosseum for all I know... S’not in the Colosseum, I, I looked—unless it’s hidden or something. But yeah, I wanted to visit Italy anyway, so it was a two-birds-one-stone sorta thing. Or I guess it’s like I aimed at two birds but only hit one?, ‘Cause I didn’t find it. They had some good soups though, good food, Rome.”

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If you're ever worried that you may one day no longer have what you currently do, you should be. That feeling is healthy, a survival instinct, self-preservation. Every human being is unique, one's individual, lived experiences priceless—espousing this kind of ideal is fine (they are true to an extent), but you must not take security in them. Do your best to keep such nebulous concepts divorced from your actual, tangible worth. Value stems from the material. People cede to substance. Train your sights on what can be seen, what can be felt, aim to take it for yourself—value stems from the material, and so to possess is to foster your own. Having anything always affords you more than just that thing.

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I found myself on a walk the other day. Pavement faintly visible beneath my feet. The town's small though, and I knew my way around. I knew most of the people too, though the streets were empty then. I passed by several shops, all already closed. If there had been anyone else up and about, I didn't notice (dark, fog, wind). I made my way through the fog, waded through it; soon (was it?) I reached the outskirts, a forest, continued on. Trees rose around me, thin and straight, branchless, barren, reaching far too high. They seemed still young. At some point among them, my foot met resistance—stairs. Anchored in the pavement and mirroring the trees surrounding them, the steps ascended deep into the fog. I began to climb.

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“How'd I hear about it? From some friends, think they heard from some'a theirs, you know how it is. Nah, I certainly don't think that makes it any less believable, like, with more people talkin' about it it feels even more believable to me to be honest, that's how I think people oughta see it at least. I mean, I do get it though, must be kinda wild hearing about it for the first time, makes sense, makes sense. It's out there though, one-hundred percent. Now, I'm not religious myself, but I stand by it—miracles do exist. There've been people in my life who've uh, who've been really, really lucky, and I've been there to see it some. With this stuff I think it's not so much what you believe that matters though, or even *that* you believe, I guess—to me it's more that you *know* what's real to you, you know?, if that makes sense.”

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Faith, usually, isn't worth it. You may practice what you need in order to ensure mental stability, but spirituality alone, like morality, will not keep you afloat. When confronted with any

obstacle, avoid retreating into the false sanctuary of a “higher power”—consider first (and only) what *you* can affect. In many cases, ~~over~~reliance on those greater than oneself is the foremost obstacle to becoming greater. As stated before, know that the more you have, the more you can do, and the less likely you are to overlook that fact.² To achieve anything, you must be aware of your options, but you must also have options. To stress this once again: *having* is requisite for *doing*.

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I found myself on a walk the other day. Up into the night sky, step by step. I looked back down and saw a pincushion, the forest now needles piercing the clouds—nothing else broke that cover (the town is low, asleep). The stairs slowly narrowed as they grew higher, and eventually I too stood upon such a point. I/t swayed in the wind, I/t was much colder up here (no coat). There was light though, from the stars in the distance, from the moon beside me. It (the moon) asked what I desired. I stared into its craters; I couldn’t answer; they were so deep, so absolute; I didn’t know. I leaned closer, until there was nothing in my periphery. I leaned closer, and with a slight breeze, I was

falling, and

falling, and

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“...falling over the edge—there were guardrails and all that stuff where I went at least, but still, kinda scary, seriously. I got a tour guide through the Canyon itself too, and there were some cool animals, but no well, of course. Yeah, it’s a bit disheartening, but being hard to find’s half the legend, right? I’m still dead-set on lookin’ for it, and even if I don’t really wanna fall into that whole ‘it’s the journey not the destination’ sorta attitude, I *have* enjoyed my search so far, so. It’s like that other thing, the ‘stop and smell the roses, pet the dogs, stack some rocks,’ I like that one. And, yeah, not *everything* I’ve heard about the well is about how great it is, but I like to think that the time I’ve taken has been worth it, and some imperfect ending’s not gonna ruin it for me. Oh, speaking of falling though, this one t-”

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[T]ime should not be taken lightly. Strive to be efficient in your accumulation of value. Deliberate carefully and commit resolutely, but do not hesitate to abandon a venture that costs more than it can pay out. One only has so much time. Lend weight to the material, but be conscious of the fact that your *having* of it is what ultimately creates value. Both parties are instrumental. Now, what exactly is it that you should do with what you have?

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I found myself on a walk the other day. On my back in an endless field of broken glass. The air was crisp, was clean, was still. There was a house a ways off. It was backlit by the dawn. I pushed myself to my feet, then towards it. Slowly. My eyes bled as I moved. The glass shone with the sunrise. I could no longer see, but I didn't stop—before I shut my eyes, I think I saw my coat on the doorstep.

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“-ime I heard a story that someone *did* find it- well, actually I’ve heard a good handful of claims like that—never a first-person one, by the way—but this one uh, stuck out to me, I still think about it every so often. Apparently a few years back some kid managed to find it, stumbled across it or something, and apparently they, well, they fell in. Or uhh, hmm. This’s kinda morbid, but what I heard was that they uh, jumped in. Yeah.”

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On the Correct Use of Things: The Application of Value

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I found myself on a walk the other day.

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“I mean, like I said earlier, I personally don’t think anybody’s found it, but, you know. If, if that story’s really true, I think that—I mean, if *I*, you know, if I also found it one day... I’d, well, you know. I’d still take a sip.”